

New York; for eight years he had been the president of the Morton Trust Company. Presently he planted himself before Mr. Morgan, mouth partially opened as if he were carefully trying to select words for an important utterance.

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"John," he said at last, "how old are you?"

Mr. Morgan's scowl would have blighted an oak. "Too old to waste my time talking to you," he growled as he strode away.

That particular morning Mr. Morgan had time only to urge upon the trust company presidents a need for united action. Hastily the New York Clearing House Association amended its by-laws so as to permit the admission of any trust company which agreed to keep a 15 per cent cash reserve. But it was clear to all of us, I think, that the big weakness was in the lack of coordination in the banking system as a whole. . . .

Those weeks in October and November were a period of swift education for most bankers, and I was certainly an eager student. I was learning that the banking reforms which I had long been preaching would have to be expressed in the form of some sort of a central banking organization. We would have to invent a wholesale banking mechanism that would relieve our economic system from the intolerable strains to which periodically it was being subjected. I was learning also that banking is not a field for weaklings. If I was strong, I had need of all my strength and my own physical reserves were being drawn upon in the same way that we were having to take assets out of the bank's vaults. I ate when I could, and slept, if at all, in the home of Mr. Stillman; at this time he had a house in Seventy-second Street.

In response to some prescient warning of the trouble to come, Mr. Stillman had returned to the United States before